

concept called Reality TV? An entertainment sham that people buy into irrespective of whether there is any semblance of reality in what is being watched. But of course we digress. When focusing on reality in technology, there are a few occasions where your reality is blurred. Everytime you play a game for instance. You get so immersed in the game that your surroundings dissolve, you almost enter that virtual world and when someone calls out for you from the “real” world you return to it with a jolt. Almost resultantly, if we might add. There are technologies out there that blur your reality at varying levels. Some embellish what you experience while some completely immerse you into an alternate reality. Augmented reality is just one of those realities at sale.

What is augmented reality anyway?

If you’ve been a Digit reader for long, you might already know what the word ‘augmented’ means. But just in case you’re not, let us try to break it down for you – the word ‘augmented’ means enhanced or increased. Simple enough right? The phrase simply means “enhanced reality”.

But if reality is what it is how does someone enhance or embellish it? By using a tool such as your smartphone. The concept of augmented reality revolves around adding more information to your world (or let’s say just your view of the world). The augmentation is usually done by adding extra data to the perception of things around us which are not visible normally. Let us say you are walking down the road (let’s assume, in a city where you have never been) and you see a fenced and open area but it doesn’t have a signboard demarcating the plot. You check on your phone and Google maps says that the area is a meditation center. See? How your mobile phone enhanced your perception of your world?

The above was a mere example to show how everyday tools help us get more out of our reality. But before you grasp the above example as one of augmented reality, it’s best we tell you that Google maps does not really come under the umbrella of augmented reality.

Imagine again, you go to Shanghai, a well known city in China. What you are looking for is a vegetarian restaurant but since everything is written in chinese which you do not understand, you are unable to figure out where to go. You take out your smartphone, connect to the internet and launch an app. This app looks through the rear camera and shows you what it sees except there’s more than just the actual scene. You point it to a building, and it shows a graphical callout that says “hotel” next to